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WASHINGTON

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PER E.O. 13526
2013-0517-m (1.04)
KBH 7/16/2019

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telcon with Chancellor Helmut Kohl of Germany
(U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Chancellor Helmut Kohl
Notetakers: Alexander Vershbow and Anthony
Gardner

DATE, TIME July 13, 1995, 6:15-6:35 p.m.
AND PLACE: Oval Office

The President: Hello? (U)

Chancellor Kohl: Hello, Bill? (U)

The President: Yes, Helmut. I'd like to talk to you about
Bosnia. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: Yes. I can well imagine your concern. The
situation is catastrophic. (U)

The President: We need to decide what we are going to do about
UNPROFOR. Jacques Chirac just called me with a radical proposal:
either we retake Srebrenica by military action with U.S., French,
UK and German ground troops, or we withdraw immediately because
otherwise we can't defend the honor of the UN. I told him that
this wasn't a good idea. Even if we retook Srebrenica, what
would we do to defend it? We couldn't be sure that the Muslims
would be any more ready to defend it than before. We agreed to
talk to our Chiefs of Staff and that they would follow up.
General Shalikashvili spoke to Admiral Lanxade. The French
military agrees that retaking Srebrenica would be a big risk for
little gain. They are focusing on reinforcing Gorazde with 1,000
French peacekeepers and reopening the Mount Igman road to
Sarajevo with the Rapid Reaction Force. We think that is more
realistic. I know you spoke to him earlier today. What do you
think? Does Chirac earnestly want to pull out UNPROFOR if we
don't agree? (C)

Let me just say one thing before turning to you: here in the U.S., the Congress is saying that the fall of Srebrenica proves that UNPROFOR is no good and that we should lift the embargo unilaterally. I'm still opposing that. I think I can defeat it, but I may have to veto it. I wanted to talk to you about the situation and get your opinion. (S)

Chancellor Kohl: Thank you, Bill. I was not able to talk to Chirac himself, but spoke to Juppe. I spoke with Chirac yesterday and the day before. In my opinion, he is, correctly, extremely upset by the whole situation. However, I think we need to clarify a few things before we go any further. First, Chirac's proposal would require UN Security Council approval. (S)

The President: Absolutely. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: I might add that the blessing of the UN is unlikely. Second, and most important, we are talking primarily about Dutch soldiers. The Dutch Government is adamantly opposed to any military action that would put their soldiers at risk. They are there and are all hostages. Any decision to take military action would clearly countervene the decision of the Dutch Government, which would be impossible for us to do. But regardless of that fact, the UN Security Council would probably withhold approval. (S)

The third problem which we should explore in greater detail is preventing the other "safe areas" from being taken. This is one of Chirac's other ideas. We need to find out if we can rally Major's support since that is where he has his soldiers. Troops from smaller countries are also on the ground; we shouldn't overlook that. (S)

The real problem at the core of the situation is that the Serbs and their leadership have been reduced to outsiders. They have great difficulty seeing any future for themselves. They are being blamed by the outside world. They have developed a "bunker mentality," in other words: "After me, chaos and the hell with it." I would favor one more discussion between the Chiefs of Staff with British participation. As you know, we don't have troops on the ground and don't plan to. What do you think? (S)

The President: I think you have made some good points. I agree that the Chiefs of Staff need to talk again. We can't do something stupid. Defending Gorazde and opening the Mount Igman road is a better course. It is still better to keep UNPROFOR there than to withdraw it. (S)

Chancellor Kohl: I agree completely: UNPROFOR should stay. On the other hand, we need to recognize that the situation is inextricable, even impossible. How can we avoid the fact that UNPROFOR troops may be taken hostage? The situation is catastrophic in the eyes of world opinion. The Serbs, these gangsters, have been taking the whole world for a ride. In that respect, Chirac is correct. (C)

What are we going to do about the Dutch? The vote taken by their government is of utmost importance. Unfortunately, a dispute has already arisen with regard to the following occurrence: either the French Foreign Minister or Defense Minister has publicly accused the troops in Srebrenica of cowardice. The Dutch thought this referred to them. (C)

The President: Perhaps he meant the Bosnians? (C)

Chancellor Kohl: Whatever the case, the Dutch took it personally. (C)

The President: That's not good. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: No, it's not. The whole situation is catastrophic. The pictures we see of refugees are terrible. Bill, this is what I would suggest we do. I would be available for further talks Friday, Saturday or Sunday between 2000 and 2400 our time, that is 1400 and 1800 Washington time. I'll be at home in Ludwigshafen, so your side should provide an interpreter. (U)

The President: We need to stay together on this. I will call you on Friday, Saturday or Sunday. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: You can count on my entire support. You can talk very frankly with me. I know what the U.S. Congress might plan. The last thing I want is for you to be maneuvered into a dead end. (C)

The President: I understand and agree. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: My best to your wife. (U)

The President: And to yours. Good-bye. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: Good-bye. (U)

-- End of Conversation --

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